ECRS Leadership

A concise guide crystallized from the writings and traditions of Eastern Cooperative Recreation School

For more than 80 years, ECRS has been fostering leaders that are at the heart of what makes ECRS special. ECRS Leaders engage every member of the group into a joyful community through a variety of recreational activities. Here are some strategies for effective and successful ECRS leadership.

ECRS Leaders Value...

Awareness and sensitivity to each group member

- demonstrating active listening and anticipating feelings and reactions
- respecting and understanding what it feels like to be a beginner or newcomer
- empowering participants to feel a part of the group

Cooperation, not competition

- including all members throughout the activity (anyone who is “eliminated” is able to continue to participate in some way)

Creating a “we” feeling among participants

- planning and thinking is focused on the group experience
- leader invites participation in an unpressured way

Appreciation for participants’ differences and uniqueness

- appreciating that there are many different ways in which people learn and participate in a group

Planning appropriately challenging, success-oriented activities

- fostering a feeling that anyone can succeed and learn
- demonstrating confidence and joy in group members’ successes
- encouraging the group to problem solve and discover success on their own

Emphasis on process, not product

- creating an experience which allows for imagination and spontaneity and a climate of freedom to play, to experiment and take positive risks

ECRS Leadership Qualities

- Understanding of and commitment to ECRS philosophy
- Focusing on the group as a whole as well as the individual group members
- Role modeling clear communication and an openness to feedback
- Committing to one's own personal growth as an ECRS leader
- Demonstrating the ability to identify and express positive observations about the group and its members

Specific strategies for successful ECRS leadership and program planning

> *"Maximize your effort to be: inclusive, fair, challenging, organized, willing to take risks, willing to fail, willing to have fun. You are the role model. Be it!"*
>
> *- Dotti Siftar*

★ Plan a distinct beginning, middle and end, for each activity

★ Break down activities into smaller steps to master the whole

★ Offer participation in an inviting, unpressured way

★ Choose material that creates a positive climate (familiarity and ease) while keeping in mind that participants learn, are challenged and respond in a variety of ways.

★ Communicate clearly and enthusiastically

★ Allow group members to solve problems themselves with the support of the leader and the support of the structure of the activity. Leaders are available to guide the group to achieve success without the leader jumping in to provide solutions. The leader encourages group members to solve their own problems without rescuing them.

★ Role model warmth, caring, enthusiasm, energy, positive communication and confidence in the group

★ Establish a safe climate where constructive feedback is possible if/ when a participant desires this. Leader role models and sets guidelines as to how to give and take feedback.

★ Communication is clear and concise. Leaders demonstrate the activity when necessary in a manner that allows group members to respond at their own level of comfort.

★ Include a mixture of new and old activities and review activities that have been presented in the past with the goal of every participant being able to gain a sense of mastery of the activity.

★ Encourage leadership in each individual while maintaining overall leadership of the group

★ Recognize each person's ability to discover and grow, while also accepting that a person may choose to remain as they are

★ Respect Language/Culture: When teaching something in another language, pronounce words correctly and give correct translation - finding the beauty in the activity or song.

Feedback for growth

ECRS leaders and feedback

From its beginnings, leadership development has been at the heart of ECRS with the philosophy that a leader's development is ongoing and not finite.

Leaders have the option of asking for feedback at the end of their class. In addition, a leader working with a liaison has the opportunity to receive feedback from their liaison.

An optional model for feedback at the end of a class or workshop:

- Participants are asked what they liked/enjoyed about the experience.
- Participants are then asked what they might have liked to be different.
- A leader shares their experience of the class and final thoughts.

Practice leaders' feedback

Within the context of a class, a leader may want to encourage class participants to **step into leadership positions by practice teaching in their class**. Class participants should be introduced as practice leaders and informed how feedback will be structured after their leadership experience.

1. Practice Leader states what went well with their leadership and activity
2. Group identifies positive observations about the leadership and activity
3. Individual states what they would change if they did it again
4. Group states their observations about how the experience could be even better
5. Individual shares final thoughts about the experience

Tips and Tricks by Class Type

Crafts

- Give enough information/techniques so people can make reasonable choices and start as soon as possible. Later, present more.
- Have a good understanding of the materials, including sufficient knowledge of possibilities, limitations, pitfalls, etc.
- Establish an environment in which people who are at different levels of comfort with crafts can work at their own level and can set their own problems to solve. This is in contrast to a "how to" class, where one either does it "right" or "wrong".
- Participants can make choices all along in the process instead of only at one point.
- Help focus participants' attention on their preferences, and build on the part of their work that pleases them.

Dance

- Understand the soul (character) of each dance in order to know what effect it is likely to have on participants. Consider the national characteristics, background, style, folklore and integrity of each dance.
- Be aware of physical demands. Share options for more or less vigorous participation.
- Break down steps, practice with music.
- Decide when to stop a dance in progress because of evident confusion on the part of some people. Balance between comfort and challenge in steps, rhythms, etc.
- Grasp and convey musical line (phrasing and rhythms).
- Work smoothly with sound equipment and/or musicians.
- Select and use, at appropriate times, those dances that can afford a beautiful feeling which comes from moving music in harmony with others.
- Be a model, but allow people to correct their own mistakes.

Drama/Small Scenes

- Communicate methods of helping actors find motivation for their characters.
- Use good quality material (a play which portrays genuine human experience).
- Set the stage to encourage physical and thus emotional movement.
- Use high emotional points as catalysts to get movement - physical and emotional - going.
- Assess how the character came across honestly.

Games

- Choose games with several potential problem-solving elements and on-going challenges, or a variety of games which collectively provide this and a variety of skills.
- Choose games in which the “it” changes frequently.
- Choose games which offer different challenges (running, thinking, singing, throwing a ball, etc.)
- Think through how the game is likely to affect people (what will participants do, how are they likely to feel …)
- Have the group in formation before you explain the rules. Be brief and clear. Demonstrate.
- Give enough information (rules and structure) without solving the problem.
- Start play as soon as possible. Often just doing it clears up any misunderstandings.
- Decide when to reinforce a rule and when to let the group handle a situation.
- Allow participants to create their own problem solving strategies within the rules of the game.
- Ask for volunteers only after the players know what will be expected of them.
- End the game at the high point of enjoyment.

Informal Dramatics

- Use warm-up games/activities.
- Provide structure while allowing for creativity and experimentation. Set ground rules for developing skit (i.e. skits have a beginning, a middle and end).
- Allow each participant to decide for themselves their own level of participation and what roles they want to play.
- Emphasize boundaries - i.e. respect participants' comfort levels, risk taking, body space, etc.

Singing (From *Songs to Sing and Sing Again* by Shelley Gordon)

- Include echo songs, lining-out songs, and open-ended songs
- Use an economy of words
- Make sure the melody is manageable
- Stick to a clear beat and familiar rhythm
- Include a variety of difficulty in songs, harmonies etc.
- Choose meaningful lyrics

Theory/Other Learning-Type Class

- Include open-ended questions and topics
- Encourage exploration of ideas
- Every person has a contribution and an experience of the situation

Wisdom from Ed Moyer 10/25/77

Encouraging leadership in others means:

- Allowing for experimentation, exploration
- Creating opportunities for different levels of leadership
- Gently encouraging, not pushing individuals
- Setting a positive climate for constructive feedback
- Encouraging group decision-making
- Sharing Leadership

The ECRS Approach to Play by Sy Kantor

(Pages 4-6 Of Play and Playfulness)

The ECRS approach to play activity starts from the first day at a school session with most of the introductory communication being done through activities such as games, songs and dances.

The message is clear. This is what we're about here. You can leave your personal history in the car or bus, step into the present, do, enjoy, communicate through play. You don't have to have played before. You will learn by doing and the leadership will facilitate your learning.

Let's assume I'm a new student at ECRS. How do I see the process here and what might it mean to me?

One thing I may notice is that the person leading the activities is looking straight at me in a friendly way, and for an instant I feel a little self-conscious. But soon I see she is taking in every other person as well.

When the leader looks my way again, I begin to feel differently about it, maybe even a little pleased.

I remain as anonymous as I dare to be, but I still count as an individual. While we are playing, I am relieved that I am not required to do anything I don't want to do, and if I do participate, whatever I do is OK. My performance apparently isn't being rated by some criterion of excellence.

Soon I seem to be dancing a folk dance, something I've never done before. I'm sure I'm going to make a fool of myself.

Each step is being taught as a sequence of a few simple movements: walk four steps in a circle, starting with the left foot and then hop on the right foot … *But when a few of these steps are put together and we're moving to music. I find myself making mistakes, I hop on the wrong foot, stumble, and bump into the person next to me. Now I've done it!*

Contrary to my expectations, the leader doesn't seem to have noticed.